Adaptability questions

Design Gurus

Here are a few behavioral questions related to time management and prioritization:

Question 1: How do you manage your workload and prioritize tasks when working on multiple projects simultaneously?

Intention of the question: The interviewer wants your actual system, not a list of tools. They are also checking whether you renegotiate when the work does not fit, or quietly let something slip.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid naming your task tracker and stopping there. Do not claim you deliver everything on time. The interesting part is what you dropped, and who you told.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "I was on two projects at once for a quarter. One was a payment integration with a fixed launch date. The other was a search rebuild with no date but a lot of attention from our head of product. Both managers believed they had most of my time."

Task: "Together the two plans needed about 1.6 times the hours I had. Neither manager knew the other's plan in detail. The first thing to fix was not my schedule. It was that belief."

Action: "I wrote one list of everything both projects expected from me, with an estimate against each line. It came to about 13 weeks of work in an 8-week quarter. I sent the same list to both managers and asked them to agree an order between themselves. That conversation took 40 minutes. I was in it, but I did not make the call. They cut two search items and moved one payment item to the next quarter. After that I sent both of them the same weekly update in the same message, so neither could be surprised. I kept mornings for the payment work, because a fixed date beats an open one."

Result: "Payments launched on its date. Search slipped by three weeks, which both managers had agreed to in advance, so it was a plan rather than a failure. What mattered was making the conflict visible in one list. While each manager could see only their own plan, they were both right. I was the only person who could see that the total did not fit."

Sample Answer 2: "On a smaller scale I run a weekly rule. Anything that arrives during the week goes on the list but not into the week, unless it is an outage. On Friday I move things in for the following week. That turns about ten interruptions a week into one decision. It also gives me a real answer when somebody asks for something on a Tuesday. I can offer Monday, or ask what to remove. Over a quarter I found I was saying yes to about the same amount of work, but switching between tasks far less."

Follow-up you should expect: "What happened to the work you dropped?"

Why they ask: Candidates describe prioritization as though the cut work disappears. They

want to know whether you tracked it or quietly abandoned it.

How to answer it: "Two of the three cut items were built the next quarter. The third was never built. After about four months I asked our head of product to close it formally rather than leave it on a list. Nobody had asked for it in that time. I keep a short list of what I cut and review it once a quarter. Roughly half turn out not to be needed. That is useful to know, because it tells me my sense of importance during a crunch is only about half right."

Question 2: Describe a situation where you had to meet a tight deadline on a project. How did you ensure the project was completed on time and met quality standards?

Intention of the question: The interviewer wants to know what you protected when time ran short. Every candidate says they kept quality. The answer is in what you gave up instead.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid saying you worked longer hours, which is not a method. Do not claim nothing was sacrificed. Name the thing you cut and say why it was the right thing to cut.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "We had six weeks to move about 400,000 customer records to a new billing provider. The old contract ended on a fixed date and there was no option to extend it."

Task: "I owned the migration. The risk was not writing the code. It was that a wrong record means a customer is billed the wrong amount. Rolling back after go-live would have been very hard."

Action: "I decided early what I would not do. I cut the admin interface that was in the plan, which was two weeks of work, and did those operations by script instead. That bought the time. Then I spent it on verification rather than features. I wrote a comparison job that read both systems and reported every record where the amounts differed. I ran it nightly against a copy for four weeks. That way the mismatch count was something we watched fall, rather than something we discovered at the end. It started at about 12,000 and reached zero in week five. I also moved 500 low-value accounts a week early, as a live test."

Result: "We moved all 400,000 records on the deadline. Nine customers were billed incorrectly in the first month, all from one case the comparison job could not see, and all corrected within two days. The admin interface shipped six weeks later and nobody needed it in between. Cutting scope bought the verification time, and the verification is what made the date safe. Longer hours would have bought neither."

Sample Answer 2: "On a shorter deadline I did the opposite and learned from it. We had four days to ship a compliance change. I skipped writing tests, because four days felt too short for them. The change worked. But a related bug three weeks later took two days to find, because I had no tests to tell me which part had broken. Two days lost against maybe four hours saved. I now treat tests as the last thing I cut rather than the first, and cut features instead. A short deadline is exactly when you cannot afford to lose the ability to check your own work."

Follow-up you should expect: "You cut the admin interface. Who agreed to that?"

Why they ask: Cutting scope is easy to describe and hard to do. They want to know whether

you had the conversation or simply decided.

How to answer it: "Our operations manager, because her team would have been the ones using it. I went to her in the first week with the trade stated plainly. An admin screen in six weeks, or scripts and a much lower chance of billing somebody wrong. She chose the scripts. She also asked that the three most common operations be scripts she could run herself, rather than a ticket to us. That was a better answer than mine. Had I cut it without asking, I would have missed that, and she would have found out at go-live."